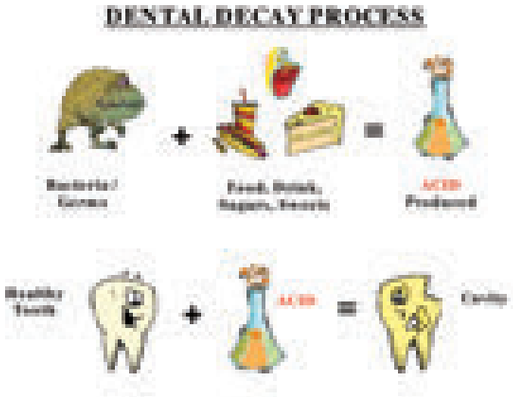


Fig. 3.7 Dental Decay process

Anaemia

Iron-deficiency anemia may develop in children whose diet is iron-deficient. Iron is an oxygen-carrying component of blood. Anemia in school-aged children may result in deleterious effects including lower school achievement due to impaired cognitive development, poor attention rate and general fatigue.

A study involving 5398 children between the ages of 6 and 16 in the United States, found that lower Maths test scores were seen in children with Iron deficiency. Children deficient in Iron were twice as likely to score below average on Maths tests and this finding was more pronounced in girls.

3.2.4 Key points for good nutrition in school-aged children

Habits developed in the formative years of life have a lasting effect on health. As a result parents need to set positive food culture through meal planning, keeping a variety of foods in supply, and setting a good example. The key points to remember as a parent/ caretaker include the following :-

- Adequate nutrition will help the child develop maximal intelligence (IQ) and well-being.
- The child should be guided to make independent food choices and eat a variety of foods.
- Malnutrition and its consequences can be prevented by eating the right kinds and amounts of foods.
- Encourage the child to practice proper hygiene at all times.

3.2.5 Dietary guidelines to keep children healthy

- The child should eat a variety of foods in order to have adequate nutrient intake.
- Nutritional requirement should meet their increasing activity and growth
- The diet should contain plenty of grain products, vegetables and fruits.
- The diet should provide enough calcium and iron to meet their growing body's requirements.
- Teach children from an early age about nutrition and healthy eating. They should be taught what happens to the food they consume.
- The diet should be moderate in sugars and salt. Avoid giving large amounts of sweet desserts, soft drinks, fruit-flavored drinks, sugar-coated cereals, chips or candy, as they have little nutritional value.
- Children tend to be bored with foods easily. so menus need to provide variety, colour, texture, taste and flavor.
- Children have varying appetites and often prefer snacky meals at frequent intervals instead of a few large ones.
- Fruits and dry fruits can be served as snack item on returning from school
- If the child does not like salads, they can be incorporated in recipes like sandwiches.

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